Before You Change Anything

7 questions worth asking when stepping into a new leadership role

I partner with leaders as they take on new roles, join companies and reshape organisations. Together, we examine what needs to change, what already works and where action cannot wait. I start by questioning the first diagnosis: the most visible problem is not always the one that needs solving.

Christian Lefevre · Managing Partner

THE FIRST MOVE

Understand what you are about to disturb.

Seven questions before you act

01 What am I actually being asked to change?
Compare your sponsor's expectations with the team's.

02 What must I preserve while I change it?
Look for the relationships and workarounds behind delivery.

03 Why does the current arrangement persist?
Find the constraint it solves before calling it resistance.

04 Where do decisions really get made?
Trace one decision: who shaped it, blocked it or delivered it?

05 Whose account have I not heard?
Hear from those living with the consequences.

06 What am I importing from my previous role?
Identify a past assumption that may not apply in this role.

07 What cannot wait, and what can I test?
Address urgent exposure; make other first steps reversible.

Avoid three traps

- **Announcing the answer early**
  A first diagnosis can become a promise before it is tested.
- **Confusing access with insight**
  The closest voices may miss where the work breaks down.
- **Redrawing the chart first**
  New reporting lines cannot settle conflicting priorities.

Test your first change

20 MINUTES / ONE SHEET

Write three headings:

- **What I know**
- **What I assume**
- **What I need to test**

List the facts, assumptions and unanswered questions behind your change. Choose one assumption to test: how, with whom and when?

IN PRACTICE Bringing industry experience into a growing biopharma

Consider a new executive hired from a leading pharma company to professionalise a growing biopharma. She proposes replacing its weekly cross-functional meeting with separate functional reviews. Before changing it, she asks the leadership team to trace a recent manufacturing delay. That meeting was where clinical, quality and supply colleagues had agreed how to protect a study milestone. She revises her proposal to preserve those joint decisions while clarifying who owns them.

FINAL THOUGHT

Your first change tells people how you lead.
Make it one you can explain, test and adjust.

NEXT NOTE After Everyone Agrees